

Chapter 4: Apprenticeship

Eric, 12 Years Ago

It had been a little over a year since the Shadowrot outbreak. The city had moved on as best they could; it was a tragedy, for sure, but the city had endured far worse. It was in times like these that Eric tried even harder to help those around him—especially those he cared about.

“Tell me again what you just said?” Nerys asked. She was in the yard, shifting some rocks in her garden area. Eric smiled any time he walked by—she said it made the yard less plain. Whether or not it did, the rock garden made him think of her and Kraekon, so he liked it whichever way she tweaked it.

“I was wondering what you thought about Kraekon becoming an apprentice.” Nerys wiped her brow—it wasn’t a particularly warm day, but she’d been exerting herself moving the rocks around.

“I think...” She paused to consider it more thoroughly. “If you’re asking me about it, I’m assuming you aren’t offering to bring him along with you to work.”

“Right. I was talking to Flavio the other day, and he happened to mention he was open to taking on an apprentice.” Eric’s eyes shifted slightly, no longer meeting his wife’s gaze. Technically, what he’d just said was true—it had just been Flavio’s response to Eric bringing the topic up. Nerys had probably immediately noticed Eric’s shiftiness, as her eyes narrowed in response.

“I see. He just *happened* to mention it, did he? Entirely unprompted, too, I imagine?” Eric sighed—she’d seen right through him. He sat on the ground next to her.

“I’m just worried about them, Nerys. He and Ember haven’t been the same since Selene passed away. I can’t be there to help them out when I’m on duty, and when I’m off duty, I want to be around you and Kraekon. I figure, if Kraekon is around, he’ll at least help cheer them up some. Plus, it’d be good for him to start learning a trade. I was about his age when I started my apprenticeship, and look how I turned out!”

“I see what you’re saying. It makes some sense, even. Plus, if Kraekon is out being an apprentice, I’ll have more time on my hands and could work more at the distributary. We should ask him if he’s interested.” Nerys smiled to herself; she was probably imagining Kraekon’s reaction to hearing he could spend more time at Ember’s house. “He’ll probably be so excited that he won’t even think about it being a job.” Her expression softened as her

voice dropped lower. “Eric... is there a reason you aren’t thinking about having him learn under you?”

Eric sighed. His wife knew him too well; he took a lot of pride in his job, so offering to let his own son learn a different trade instead of following in the family business, like Eric had, seemed... strange. Concerning, even.

“The voices are getting louder, Nerys. Bolder. I don’t want him risking his life if he doesn’t have to; he could live a long, happy life if he keeps away from the shadows.”

“Eric, we’ve talked about this. No one else has heard the voices; they’re all in your head. But even *if* they were real, the shades can’t come in. They can’t get us in here—we’re safe as long as the Lumis holds, and if it fails, no one will be safe.”

“I know, I know. I keep trying to tell myself that, but then I hear them again. The things they’re threatening to do to you, to our son... I can’t even sleep well if you aren’t with me, Nerys. You and him are everything to me. Working as a blacksmith is an honorable profession, and it still would be a way he could contribute to Duskwatch. It’d just... be safer.” Nerys slid closer and wrapped her arms around his large frame as well as she could. He pulled her close and leaned his head on hers.

“Okay. If you’re that worried, I’ll support you. But if he decides he wants to follow in your footsteps later on, I hope you’ll let him make that choice. If he’s going to eventually join Duskwatch, I’d want him to learn from the absolute best they have to offer.” She poked her finger to his nose and gave him a warm smile; Eric smiled back, his own flame rekindled by hers. Tomorrow, Kraekon would be on the road to a better future—and maybe he’d light up his friend’s life along the way.